

2 Mozilla Firefox

Who has not heard of Firefox? For a good period of time, Firefox was the leading open source browser worldwide. Even though it is slowly being replaced by Google Chrome, it is still a worthy choice and way better than good old Internet Explorer.

If, however, Firefox does not impress you, do take a look at the open source version of Chrome, named Chromium.

Website: <http://www.mozilla.org/en-US/firefox/new/>
Chromium: www.chromium.org

3 Mozilla Thunderbird

If you rely on software such as MS Outlook to manage your email, you should consider giving Mozilla Thunderbird a try. Apart from helping you manage your email effectively, Thunderbird comes loaded with a plethora of productivity features such as Calendar, Task Management, and so on. All in all, Thunderbird is a great free alternative to costly e-mail management tools.

Website: <https://www.mozilla.org/en-US/thunderbird/>

4 The GIMP

The GIMP is a free and open source image editing program that runs on various platforms, such as Linux, Mac and, of course, Windows. If you are looking for an alternative to Photoshop for everyday image editing needs but do not want to empty your bank account, you should migrate to the GIMP. The software is backed by a loyal community and comes with various tools, brushes and other add-ons to help you get the most out of it.

Website: www.gimp.org

5 InkScape

While the GIMP is for everyday image editing and authoring, InkScape is an open source tool for working with vector graphics. In fact, InkScape is a rather powerful and versatile piece of software that even gives proprietary and mammoth vector editors a run for their money!

Website: www.inkscape.org

6 Scribus

Scribus is an open source desktop publishing program that helps you create professional page layouts and press-ready page designs. Apart from having a user friendly layout, Scribus is also backed by extensive documentation and offers a wide number of features such as colour separation, CMYK and spot colours, ICC colour management and PDF creation.

Website: <http://www.scribus.net/>

7 VLC Media Player

VLC Media Player has grown so popular that when it comes to video playback, no matter which

operating system you might be using, VLC often serves as the native application. The default media player program in Windows, commonly called Windows Media Player, does not really offer codecs out of the box. If you need a media player that supports a wide range of audio and video codecs, VLC Media Player has got you covered! No matter where your media resides—audio CD, video DVD, hard drive, or a live stream off the Internet—VLC Player will not let you down. It also comes with media conversion and streaming features.

Website: <http://www.videolan.org/vlc/>

8 ClamWin AV

ClamWin Antivirus is an open source antivirus scanner for your Windows device. It comes with a GPL licence and has been adopted by over 600,000 users worldwide. Apart from a regularly updated virus definitions database, Clam AV also offers scheduled scans and comes with an add-on for MS Outlook. Sadly, Clam AV does not offer realtime antivirus protection.

Website: <http://www.clamwin.com/>

9 Audacity

If you are into audio editing and recording, purchasing closed source proprietary software can be a costly option. There is no need to panic, however, because Audacity can serve as an excellent tool. It is a free and open source audio editing and sound recording software that works on multiple operating systems including MS Windows. It comes with numerous sound effects and audio libraries.

Website: <http://audacity.sourceforge.net/>

10 PeaZip

The most popular options for working with archived files on Windows are WinRAR or WinZip. However, if you are looking for a free and open source alternative, PeaZip is a worthy contender. It supports over 150 archive file types, has been coded using Free Pascal, and even lets you protect, encrypt and split your files. The default version for Windows comes with certain third party add-ons that are not open source. You can, though, download the plain PeaZip installer which is totally open source. The PeaZip software in itself is licensed under LGPL v3 and is entirely open source.

Website: www.peazip.org 

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Writer and the editor of an e-journal named *Brave New World* (www.bravenewworld.in), the author writes for several print magazines as well as technology blogs. He is the author of *'Sufism: A Brief History'*. His primary areas of interest include open source, mobile development, Web CMSs and vector art. Sufyan blogs at www.sufyanism.com and you can also connect with him on Facebook at www.facebook.com/sufyanism